

JAMES WESTERNAUSTRALIA EDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we're visiting Western Australia and I have James Neill with me, the UK market manager for Tourism Western Australia. James, welcome to the program. Thanks very much for having me.

Now James, Western Australia, for someone who hasn't been there, it's an enormous state. It takes up virtually half of Australia. The capital is Perth and tell us a bit about your role promoting the state and a bit about the state itself.

As you said, I'm the UK market manager for Tourism Western Australia, so my remit is to promote the destination as much as possible to UK holidaymakers, essentially. It's a fantastic destination to work for, obviously. I've had a love affair with WA for a very long time.

A great destination that offers bucket loads of experiences for our customers and our guests. They can experience everything from beautiful food and wine, landscapes, amazing scenery, otherworldly experiences that are totally unique that you couldn't get anywhere else in the world. The capital is Perth and Perth is such a beautiful city.

It has a huge yachting background. That big America's Cup win back in 1983 and then the subsequent America's Cup competition in Perth itself. For yachties, for people who love seafood, wines, it's a fantastic place to start off your Western Australian adventure.

Absolutely, so Perth is a key gateway into Australia on the West Coast. It's a very vibrant city, very modern, very clean and extremely safe as well. It offers some amazing dining, great hotels and experiences and the beauty of Perth is that you can easily get to some amazing destinations within maybe half an hour's car journey.

So, for example, you could take a car or even actually a boat trip down the Swan River and actually experience some of the amazing original vineyards that align the Swan River. We also have an amazing port town of Fremantle which has a really interesting colonial history. Also it has some amazing cafes and coffee shops, a very vibrant sort of arty and bohemian sort of style to it as well.

It's also a location where you can take a ferry ride across to Rocknest Island. It only takes about half an hour and Rocknest Island is a beautiful island. There's no cars there.

You can hire out e-bikes and travel around. You can even stay on the island as well. The main reason to go, of course, is to meet the Smiling Quokka that lives there in abundance and you can go over there and as many people have done before, including celebrities, get your selfie with the Smiling Quokka as well.

They're very tame and happy to pose for the camera for you as well. Within sort of the Perth

surrounds, we have some easy to access wildlife encounters. Just 45 minutes south of Perth, you come to the town of Rockingham where you can actually swim with wild dolphins and even sea lions as well.

So it's an aquatic paradise really, Western Australia, that has multiple experiences and I said all very accessible and easy to get to from the city centre of Perth. Going north from Perth, you have fantastic centres like Broome and those areas are just amazing. Absolutely, so Broome in the northwest of the state is our gateway to the Kimberley region.

The Kimberley region is half a million square kilometres of wilderness. One of the last true great wildernesses left in the world. It is an absolute haven for wildlife but also amazing landscapes, Aboriginal culture, lots of rock art in the area and obviously home to the Purnululu National Park which houses the world-famous Bungle Bungle mountain range as well.

It's a truly spectacular site where you can take a scenic trip over the over the Bungle Bungles and witness those beautiful rock formations that have taken millions of years to form. We also have a lot of expedition cruising, luxury high-end cruising in that region as well. So you can get to areas that are very remote, not accessible by car and feel that you're experiencing something that very few people get to witness.

So a huge amount of exclusivity. Some of the highlights of cruising in that area include the horizontal falls where water gushes through a narrow gap. We also have the Montgomery Reef.

Tide levels change dramatically in this area and you get waterfalls coming off the top of the reef at low tide which is a truly spectacular thing to see. And what about the outback experiences? Western Australia is so vast and it offers so many outback opportunities, right? Absolutely. So the outback in the Kimberley has some absolutely beautiful luxury places to stay but we also have in the very south of the state somewhere called the Golden Outback which has beautiful beaches all the way stretching along to the town of Esperance.

We have Lucky Bay which has beautiful white sandy beaches. You've probably seen photographs of kangaroos jumping around on that beach. Voted one of the world's best beaches.

It also has some beautiful coastline down there in that region as well. Again a chance to sort of really feel like you're getting away from everything, really relaxing and sort of being at one with nature. What was your background? How did you come to discover Western Australia in the first place? Did you backpack there or how did you get involved with Western Australia? A long time ago now, I won't tell you how many years, but I did do my backpacking around Australia.

I was actually in Australia for a year and I started off my adventure in Western Australia. I actually remember coming into Australia with a couple of friends and we decided to buy a car together. An old-fashioned Ford Falcon station wagon.

A horrible yellow colour but we traveled extensively through Western Australia and around sort of the rest of Australia as well actually. But WA was even then my favourite state. I absolutely loved the experiences that I had in that state and my love affair for the destination has continued and it's almost come full circle.

I've worked in the travel industry for over 20 years now so it's nice to come back and actually work on a destination that I'm extremely passionate about. And speaking of that vastness, you have the Nullarbor Plain which is from Adelaide over to Perth. It's one of the straightest longest roads in the entire world.

A whole experience in itself. It's an experience that not many people have actually had but a true great experience nonetheless. Also there is an opportunity to take a train journey, one of the world's great train journeys across the Nullarbor Plain as well.

The Indian Pacific train that travels across the whole of Australia from Perth. So a fantastic experience for railway lovers and people wanting sort of a unique experience as well. We're chatting with James Neil, the UK market manager of Tourism Western Australia and James how can people find out more online about Tourism Western Australia and all the wonderful things the state has to offer? Well obviously they can go to our website which is westernaustralia.com and you can plan a journey on there.

There's actually a really useful tool that puts sort of a journey together for you and it will highlight lots of different other experiences that you can have in that region as well. So I would say that would be a starting point. Obviously we work with a lot of agents across the globe, not just in the UK, counterparts in many Asian countries but also in the US as well and obviously we have an extensive network of Australian specialists that absolutely love the destination and are very well trained and obviously most of them we've managed to get out and visit the location as well firsthand so they can actually tell you about some of the experiences they had and really recommend the ideal holiday for you.

One or two of your hidden gems that you would recommend to people that are a bit off the usual beaten track? I guess for me one of the highlights has to be the coral coast so the Ningaloo Reef that we have in Western Australia is a fringing coral coast which means you can swim directly off the beach and enjoy the beautiful coral and amazing tropical fish but one of the highlights of that region has to be swimming with whale sharks. Whale sharks go through that region between March and July and are absolutely majestic stunning creatures. We also have humpback whales in that region as well so some amazing aquatic wildlife that can be seen.

That would probably be my favorite part of WA and an absolute gem. If anyone can get up there they will absolutely love it and have an amazing time. Well Western Australia is waiting for everyone from across the world and thank you James for being part of Travel Radio's World End Australia.

Thanks very much nice to meet you and have a fantastic time for while you're in Cannes. Thank you.